penetrating East Pakistani territory. Although the Pakistanis hoped for assistance from friendly states such as the United States or China, none was forthcoming, and Pakistan was left to face India alone. The Indians made quick work of East Pakistan, capturing the capital of Dhaka by December 16 and declaring a cease-fire the next day.[25]

The consequences of Pakistan's loss were enormous. India had split Pakistan's Eastern and Western wings, capturing thousands of square miles of territory and tens of thousands of prisoners. India's overwhelming victory made clear that this was unlikely to happen in the future. Indeed, the Pakistanis would face the possibility of catastrophic defeat if they challenged the Indians again. This enhanced Indian confidence and undermined the Pakistanis' sense of martial superiority, cultivated over centuries of Muslim military dominance. The war also demonstrated that the Pakistanis could not depend on friendly states to ensure its survival. Finally, Pakistan's loss demonstrated that religion could not ensure state cohesion in South Asia. Ethnolinguistic differences had torn Pakistan asunder in 1971, despite the supposedly unifying force of Islam. Militarily, psychologically, diplomatically, and politically, Pakistan emerged from the Bangladesh war badly weakened.[26]

Indo-Pakistani relations became more stable following the Bangladesh conflict. Under the 1972 Simla Agreement, which reestablished diplomatic ties between the two countries following the war, India and Pakistan agreed to settle future disputes bilaterally and to respect the line of control separating Indian and Pakistani Kashmir. The Indians were satisfied with the post-Bangladesh settlement, which they believed would prevent the Pakistanis from involving outside parties such as the United Nations in the Kashmir dispute and from violently challenging Kashmir's territorial division. The Pakistanis, for their part, remained unhappy with territorial arrangements on the subcontinent. They continued to view the division of Kashmir as illegitimate and were smarting badly from the loss of their Eastern wing. However, they were not wholly dissatisfied with the Simla Agreement, which they interpreted quite differently from the Indians. The Pakistanis believed that, despite its emphasis on bilateralism, the agreement did not forbid them from referring the